WITS AHEAD RESEARCH GROUP

The AHEAD Fortnightly

Issue 3 · 29 October 2026 · Wits School of Education, University of the Witwatersrand

This fortnight the loudest theme was Africa insisting on building its own AI capability rather than only adopting what is built elsewhere: researchers at Wits and the University of the Free State both told audiences that the continent must set its own research and data agenda, Ghana's national AI strategy was praised for readiness but found thin on classroom detail, and the World Bank warned that AI's benefits could bypass the poorest households unless power, connectivity and skills are in place first. Alongside that ran a quieter debate on trust: a Dutch minister called AI-written theses fraud while universities replied that detection scores cannot prove it, and a new study found that students earning the same grade can have done very different amounts of their own thinking. For us at Wits AHEAD, both strands point the same way, towards building the human capability to judge these tools rather than simply deploy them, and this issue reaches you in thirteen languages.

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1

NEWS · 18 OCTOBER 2026 · KOREA, SINGAPORE AND THE UNITED KINGDOM

Universities in Korea, Singapore and the United Kingdom take different paths to redesign teaching for AI

The Korea Times reports that Korean universities have added more than 4,000 places in AI and semiconductor-related fields since 2024 and that applications to AI departments at twenty major universities rose by 16% this year, while the government has had to cap new advanced-technology places at 434 for 2027 for want of staff and facilities. The same article contrasts this expansion with Nanyang Technological University in Singapore, which plans to fold AI into 40% of its undergraduate courses by 2030, and with King's College London and the London School of Economics, which are redesigning assessment and giving students and staff licensed access to AI tools rather than returning to handwritten exams.

> **Why it matters:** For Wits AHEAD's pillar on generative AI in higher education, the comparison sets out two different responses to the same pressure, building more AI capacity or redesigning what and how students are assessed, a choice South African universities are weighing at the same time.

The Korea Times · koreatimes.co.kr · Read at source

Jung, D.-H. (2026, October 18). Korea focuses on AI majors while global universities rewrite rules of education. *The Korea Times*. koreatimes.co.kr/southkorea/education/20261018/cover-story-korea-focuses-on-ai-majors-while-global-universities-rewrite-rules-of-education

2

REPORT · 17 OCTOBER 2026 · GLOBAL

Seven-country study finds universities at very different stages of AI readiness

A seven-country study by WISE and the Institute of International Education finds universities at very different stages of generative AI readiness, with policy, student attitudes and infrastructure all uneven. At one private Ghanaian university 64% of faculty reported a clear AI policy, against 27% at a public research university, even though 89% of faculty across the study had already used AI themselves. The researchers warn that because leading AI models are trained mainly on English and other dominant languages, African and other Global South institutions risk staying consumers of AI rather than builders of it.

> **Why it matters:** For Wits AHEAD's pillar on responsible AI, ethics, equity and policy, the study shows that readiness gaps between institutions, not only between countries, could widen rather than narrow inequality in how higher education adopts AI.

WISE and the Institute of International Education (IIE), reported by University World News · universityworldnews.com · Read at source

Abd Elgalil, T. (2026, October 17). The global AI divide: Higher education's readiness gap. *University World News*. universityworldnews.com/post.php?story=20261015140656705

3

NEWS · 15 OCTOBER 2026 · NETHERLANDS

Dutch minister calls AI-written theses 'fraud', universities say detection scores cannot prove it

A Dutch broadcaster's review of hundreds of recent master's theses at twelve universities found that in about one in five, chatbots such as ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini had contributed more text than the student had. Education minister Rianne Letschert called this 'fraud', but the universities' own body, Universiteiten van Nederland, said a detection score alone cannot prove misconduct and that the real question is how assessments are designed. Delft, Utrecht and Leiden have each restricted or banned AI detection tools on student work, arguing they are unreliable.

> **Why it matters:** For Wits AHEAD's pillar on generative AI in higher education, the row shows how quickly an academic integrity dispute can turn political once a minister weighs in, and why the group argues for redesigning assessment rather than relying on detection software.

Times Higher Education · timeshighereducation.com · Read at source

Asaf, S. (2026, October 15). Dutch minister criticises 'fraud' as 'fifth of theses AI-written'. *Times Higher Education*. timeshighereducation.com/news/dutch-minister-criticises-fraud-fifth-theses-ai-written

RESEARCH AND REPORTS

Study proposes voice-based AI interviews as a richer alternative to end-of-semester course surveys

Technical University of Munich and the MIT Sloan School of Management, posted to arXiv · 18 October 2026 · Pillar 1: Generative AI in higher education. For Wits AHEAD's pillar on generative AI in higher education, the study points to a practical use for conversational AI inside teaching: turning a weak, low-response feedback loop into one detailed enough for lecturers and institutions to act on.

Tamme, T., Schilling, L., & Hantel, A. (2026). Voice-based AI feedback in higher education: A field study on quality and actionability. *arXiv*. doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2610.25560

Russell Group students say they are taught little about AI, Bett UK survey finds

Times Higher Education · 15 October 2026 · Pillar 1: Generative AI in higher education. For Wits AHEAD's pillar on generative AI in higher education, the finding that research-intensive universities teach AI skills less than other institutions do raises a direct equity question about which graduates enter an AI-shaped labour market prepared.

Luckhurst, G. (2026, October 15). Students report little AI teaching on Russell Group courses. *Times Higher Education*. timeshighereducation.com/news/students-report-little-ai-teaching-russell-group-courses

New framework guides statistics and data science educators on teaching responsible generative AI use

arXiv · 15 October 2026 · Pillar 3: STEM and teacher education. Pillar 3 (AI and analytics in STEM and teacher education) needs classroom ready frameworks, not only policy statements; this one gives Wits AHEAD a working model for teaching generative AI literacy inside a quantitative discipline.

Davies, V., Alexander, C., Gaskell, J., Parker, M., & Lever, J. (2026). A framework for teaching the responsible and effective use of generative AI in statistics and data science. *arXiv*. doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2610.21663

FROM THE GROUP

15 Oct 2026 **The AHEAD Fortnightly, Issue 2**
Missed it? Issue 2 is online at witsahead.org/newsletter/ in thirteen languages.

12 Sep 2026 **Incoming doctoral candidate registered**
Educational leadership, curriculum reform and graduate unemployment; proposal under supervisory review.

12 Sep 2026 **Respondent and examiner accepted for a doctoral proposal presentation**
Prof. Michael Bodunrin (Engineering) joins the panel; cross-faculty supervision in practice.

12 Sep 2026 **Daily briefing launched on the Wits AHEAD website**
News, research, video and readings on the group's remit, curated every morning and archived.

A READING WE PROFFER

Development as Freedom Amartya Sen, Oxford University Press (1999). The H in AHEAD. Start here.

With best wishes for the fortnight ahead,



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